

IT PROJECT MANAGEMENT

TOPIC 13

CLOSING PROJECTS

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

a. Describe **common ways to close** or terminate projects
b. Discuss the **process of closing a project** or phase performed as part of project integration management when using a predictive approach to managing projects
c. Explain **the importance of a project close-out** meeting and **knowledge transfer**
d. Describe the contents of a customer acceptance/project completion form, final project report, and lessons-learned report
e. Discuss **unique aspects of closing agile/hybrid projects**
f. Summarize advice on closing projects

CLOSING PROCESSES

CLOSING PROJECT

- Closing Project includes **archiving** project information, **ensuring** the planned work is complete, and **releasing** organizational resources.
- It often includes a final presentation and report.
- For both projects that are completed and those that are canceled before completion, it is important to **formally close the project** and reflect on what can be learned to improve future projects.

COMMON WAYS TO CLOSE OR TERMINATE A PROJECT

1. ***Integration:*** A project is *completed, and products and services created are integrated into operations*.

   This is the most common approach. Project staff and other resources are released and distributed into the organization.

2. ***Addition:*** A project creates a new product or service that results in a new unit in the organization, such as a department, division, or company. Project staff and other resources move into the new unit.

3. ***Extinction:*** A project may end because it was successful and achieved its goals, and there is no need for further work.

   Another form of extinction is when a project is stopped because it was unsuccessful or superseded. A special case of termination by extinction, when there is a sudden end to a project.

4. ***Starvation:*** A project can also be terminated by *decreasing its budget or suddenly ending funding.*

   This approach is also known as withdrawal of life support. The reason for starving a project is generally to shadow the failure of no accomplishment of the goals. Management sometimes uses this approach to avoid embarrassment.

SUMMARY OF CLOSING OUTPUTS

Knowledge area	Closing process	Outputs
Project integration management	Close project or phase	Project documents updates Final product, service, or result transition Final report Organizational process assets updates

PROJECT INTEGRATION MANAGEMENT

The main outputs of closing a project or phase are as follows:

1. ***Project documents updates:*** All project documents should be reviewed and marked as final versions.
2. ***Final product, service, or result transition:*** Project sponsors are usually most interested in making sure that the final products, services, or results are delivered and transitioned to the appropriate part of the organization.
3. ***Final report:*** A final project report and presentation are also commonly used during project closing.
4. ***Updates to organizational process assets:*** Examples of organizational process assets include plans, processes, policies, procedures, and knowledge bases, such as templates and lessons-learned reports.

SAMPLE CUSTOMER ACCEPTANCE/PROJECT COMPLETION FORM

Customer Acceptance/Project Completion Form

June 30

Project Name: Just-In-Time Training Project
Project Manager: Kristin Maur

I (We), the undersigned, acknowledge and accept delivery of the work completed for this project on behalf of our organization. My (Our) signature(s) attest(s) to my (our) agreement that this project has been completed. No further work should be done on this project.

Signature area (use company standard for signatures)

1. Was this project completed to your satisfaction? __**X**__ Yes _____ No
2. Please rate project performance based on a scale of 1 to 10, with 10 being the best. _**9**_
3. Please provide the main reasons for your satisfaction or dissatisfaction with this project. The project met and exceeded my expectations. In my 15 years with this company, I have never seen workers so interested in training courses. Kristin effectively coordinated all of the people who worked on this project. We worked with a number of new suppliers, and everything went very smoothly.
4. Please provide suggestions on how our organization could improve its project delivery capability in the future.

One suggestion would be to try to improve our estimating and forecasting abilities. The project costs were slightly over budget, even with some reserve built in. The schedule buffer prevented the project from finishing late. We also need to improve the way we forecast the number of people who want to take courses. The demand for the Web-based courses was much higher than expected. Even though that was a pleasant surprise, it was still poor forecasting and caused extra work for project and support staff.

Thank you for your inputs.

SAMPLE FINAL REPORT

Final Project Report
June 20

Project Name: Just-In-Time Training Project

1. Project Description and Summary of Results
2. Original and Actual Scope
3. Original and Actual Schedule
4. Original and Actual Budget
5. Quality Objectives, Verification, and Validation
6. Risk/Issue Summary
7. Project Assessment
8. Lessons Learned Summary
9. Transition Plan
10. Training Benefits Plan

Attachments:

A. Key Project Management Documentation
- Business case
- Project charter
- Project management plan
- Performance reports

B. Product-Related Documentation
- Survey and results
- Summary of user inputs
- Report on research of existing training
- Partnership agreements
- Course materials
- Intranet site training information
- Summary of course evaluations

SAMPLE TRANSITION PLAN

Transition Plan
June 20

Project Name: Just-In-Time Training Project

Introduction

The main goal of this project was to develop a new training program at Global Construction to provide just-in-time training to employees on key topics, including supplier management, negotiating skills, project management, and software applications. New courses were developed and offered in instructor-led, DVD, and Web-based formats. These courses will continue to be offered at Global Construction for the next several years. This transition plan describes the work required to support these courses.

Assumptions

- Support for the just-in-time training will be handled by staff in affected operational departments, including the training, IT, HR, and contract departments.
- Funding for the required support is budgeted at $400,000 per year for three years. These funds will be used to pay staff in the operational departments supporting this project, experts providing information for courses, and suppliers providing training materials and courses.
- New course topics will be developed under a new project and are not part of this transition plan.

Organization

The Training Director, Lucy Camerena, will lead all efforts to support the Just-In-Time Training courses. Staff from the training, IT, HR, and contract departments will provide support as required. See the organizational chart provided in Attachment 1.

Work Required

The main work required to support the training developed from this project includes:

- Maintaining related information on the intranet site
- Handling course registration
- Determining the number of courses offered each year and when they will be offered
- Providing classrooms for the instructor-led training
- Coordinating with suppliers for all training courses
- Planning and managing the internal experts who provide some of the training and expert support for the courses
- Collecting course evaluation information and suggestions for changing the content or format of courses
- Reporting information to senior management on a monthly basis

See Attachment 2 for detailed information on the work required.

Schedule

See Attachment 3 for a draft schedule of work to be performed in the next year. The Training Director is responsible for scheduling and managing the work required to support the Just-In-Time training.

SAMPLE LESSONS-LEARNED REPORT

Lessons-Learned Report

June 20

Project Name: Just-In-Time Training Project
Project Sponsor: Lucy Camerena
Project Manager: Kristin Maur
Project Dates: July 1 – June 30
Final Budget: $1,072,000

1. Did the project meet scope, time, and cost goals?
We did meet scope and time goals, but we had to request an additional $72,000, which the sponsor approved. We actually exceeded scope goals by having more people take training courses than planned, primarily the Web-based courses.

2. What was the success criteria listed in the project scope statement?
The following statement outlined the project scope and success criteria:
"Our sponsor has stated that the project will be a success if the new training courses are all available within one year, if the average course evaluations are at least 3.0 on a 1-5 scale, and if the company recoups the cost of the project in reduced training costs within two years after project completion."

3. Reflect on whether or not you met the project success criteria.
All of the new training courses were offered within a year, and the course evaluations averaged 3.4 on a 5-point scale. The number of people who took the Web-based training courses far exceeded our expectations. Because the Web-based training is more cost-effective than the instructor-led training, we are confident that the cost of the project will be recouped in less than two years.

4. In terms of managing the project, what were the main lessons your team learned from this project?
The main lessons we learned include the following:

- Having good communications was instrumental to project success. We had a separate item in the WBS for stakeholder communications, which was very important. Moving from traditional to primarily Web-based training was a big change for Global Construction, so the strong communications was crucial. The intranet site information was excellent, thanks to support from the IT department. It was also very effective to have different departments create project description posters to hang in their work areas. They showed creativity and team spirit.

SAMPLE LESSONS-LEARNED REPORT (CONT')

- Teamwork and supplier partnerships were essential. It was extremely helpful to take time to develop and follow a team charter or contract for the project team and to focus on developing good partnerships with suppliers. Everyone was very supportive of each other.
- Good planning paid off when plans were executed. We spent a fair amount of time developing a good project charter, scope statement, WBS, schedules, and other plans. Everyone worked together to develop these planning documents, and there was strong buy-in. We kept the plans up-to-date and made key project information available for everyone on a secure website.
- Creativity and innovation are infectious: Many creative and innovative ideas were used on this project. After departments had so much fun making their posters in their work areas, people picked up on the idea of being creative and innovative throughout the project. Everyone realized that training and learning could be enjoyable.
- The project steering committee was very effective. It was extremely helpful to meet regularly with the project steering committee. Having members from different departments in the company was very important and helped in promoting the training created as part of this project.

5. Describe one example of what went right on this project.

We were skeptical about hiring an outside consultant to help us develop a short list of potential suppliers for the training courses, but it was well worth the money. We gained useful information very quickly, and the consultant made excellent recommendations and helped us develop partnerships that benefited suppliers and us.

SAMPLE LESSONS-LEARNED REPORT (CONT')

6. Describe one example of what went wrong on this project.
The senior supplier management specialist assigned to the team at the beginning of the project was not a good fit. The project manager should have more involvement in selecting project team members.
7. What will you do differently on the next project based on your experience working on this project?
For future training projects, it would be helpful to line up experts and mentors further in advance. We underestimated the number of people who would take the Web-based courses, and participants liked the interactive features, such as getting expert advice and having a list of people willing to mentor them on various topics. We were scrambling to get people and had to figure out how to organize them in an effective manner.

PROJECT CLOSE-OUT MEETING

- It is good practice to hold a **close-out meeting** as a project nears completion or termination. At this meeting, like the *kick-off* meeting, you should invite **key project stakeholders.**
- The project champion should start off the meeting, and the project manager and his/her team should review information such as:
  1. The scope, time, and cost goals and outcomes
  2. The success criteria and results in achieving them
  3. Main changes that occurred during the project and how they were addressed
  4. The main lessons learned on the project
  5. A summary of the transition plan

KNOWLEDGE TRANSFER

- **Knowledge transfer** is the process of communicating knowledge that was developed by one person or in one part of an organization to another person or other parts of an organization.
- In particular, people who will take over products or results produced as part of the project would need to spend time with project team members so they understand what is involved in detail.
- Many organizations are working hard to improve the knowledge transfer process, since employee knowledge or human capital is one of their key assets.
- It is crucial, therefore, to make project knowledge transfer a priority, especially if the benefits of a project are not achieved immediately.

CLOSING AGILE/HYBRID PROJECTS

- Daily Scrum: You can think of these meetings as **providing closure for the day before**. Teams focus on progress toward the sprint goal and produce an actionable plan for the next day of work. If there are impediments, they address them quickly. If the team is not following the Scrum values or processes, corrections are made. Project managers (or Scrum masters, or any team member, in fact) must always be aware of people on their team and address any obvious or subtle problems.
- Sprint reviews: Sprint reviews provide **closure for sprints,** and sometimes entire projects. Stakeholders provide feedback at sprint reviews, inspect the outcome of the sprint, and determine future adaptations. If customers do not see value in what the team produced, they can suggest no future sprints. Remember that sprints can be one month *or less*. If requirements change quickly, it might make sense to have sprints that only last a week or even less.
- Sprint retrospectives: The team discusses what went well during the sprint, what problems it encountered, and how those problems were or were not solved. They identify changes to improve team effectiveness and address them as soon as possible. This event is **similar to a lessons learned**, but it only focuses on a particular sprint. When a project ends, teams should hold a *final retrospective* to focus on *all* lessons learned.

CLOSING AGILE/HYBRID PROJECTS

Similar to a predictive project close-out meeting, participants should review:

1. The goals and outcomes of the project
2. Main changes that occurred during the project and how they were addressed
3. The main lessons learned on the project
4. A summary of the transition plan

ADVICE ON CLOSING PROJECTS

Although project teams (predictive, agile, and hybrid) do not typically spend much time on closing projects, it is important to do it well.

- It is important to plan for project closing. On a predictive project, there should be deliverables in the WBS and resources allocated to perform project closing.
- It will be much easier to close a project if the project team captures lessons learned and other important information required for closing as soon as possible.
  - For example, the project team should have a lessons-learned repository where everyone can document lessons learned as they occur. A simple blog would work well for this purpose, or team members could document lessons learned as part of progress reports. Because many agile teams prefer discussing information instead of documenting it, capturing key points in some fashion, like a blog, would also be appropriate.
- Project managers should take time to thank their team and other project stakeholders and have some type of closing celebration.
  - Just having a team lunch or informal gathering might be appropriate, or having a virtual celebration of some sort is appreciated, as long as you make it fun! If it was a big, highly successful project, a more formal celebration and rewards would be appropriate.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

- Closing projects or phases involves **finalizing all activities** and bringing the project or phase to an **orderly end**.
- It includes **archiving** project information, **ensuring** the planned work is complete, and **releasing** organizational resources.
- Closing outputs related to integration management include project documents updates, final products, services, or result transition, a final report, and updates to organizational process assets.
- It is also good practice to hold a **close-out meeting** and hold some type of celebration when a project is over.
- Agile/hybrid projects also include closing activities.
- Teams should transition work to operational groups as needed, hold a project close-out meeting, hold a final retrospective to review lessons learned for the entire project, and celebrate the project's end.
- Helpful advice for closing projects includes planning for closure, documenting lessons learned and other important information as soon as possible, and celebrating project closure.